

Section

SEID 2364 – Assignment 11 ACM and IEEE Code Analysis

Part 1 – Intervention Strategy and Case Focus

The selected intervention strategy is COVID-19 misinformation moderation on social media platforms. During the pandemic, platforms such as Facebook, YouTube, and X removed, labeled, or downranked misleading content related to vaccines, masks, and public-health measures. The intervention was designed and implemented by social media companies together with public-health authorities and fact-checking organizations. The people affected included ordinary users, healthcare workers, governments, and communities relying on online information. The governance context mainly relates to Europe, where moderation efforts were connected to transparency and public-health cooperation. The intervention is ethically complicated because moderation may reduce harmful misinformation while also creating concerns about censorship, freedom of expression, and platform power over public discourse.

Part 2 – ACM Code Analysis

One relevant ACM principle is avoiding harm. The ACM Code of Ethics states that computing professionals should minimize negative consequences of computing systems. In this case, moderating dangerous misinformation about COVID-19 vaccines or treatments may reduce public harm and protect health. Another relevant ACM principle is honesty and transparency. Platforms should clearly explain moderation policies and allow users to understand why content was removed or restricted. Ethical concerns increase when moderation decisions become opaque or difficult to appeal.

Part 3 – IEEE Code Analysis

One important IEEE principle is prioritizing public safety, health, and welfare. During the pandemic, limiting false medical information could help reduce health risks and misinformation-related harm. Another relevant IEEE principle is maintaining technical competence and responsible judgment. Engineers and developers responsible for moderation systems must ensure that algorithms and moderation tools are accurate and fair. Poorly designed moderation systems may wrongly suppress legitimate discussion or scientific debate.

Part 4 – Comparison

Both ACM and IEEE emphasize reducing harm and acting responsibly. However, ACM focuses more strongly on transparency, accountability, and ethical conduct in computing systems, while IEEE emphasizes public safety and technical responsibility. ACM is more useful for analyzing information governance and user rights, while IEEE is stronger when evaluating engineering reliability and system safety. Together, both frameworks provide complementary perspectives on professional responsibility.

Part 5 – Reflection

I believe the ACM Code provides slightly more useful guidance for this case because misinformation moderation involves communication systems, transparency, accountability, and public trust. The ACM principles directly address how computing professionals should manage information-related harms. However, the IEEE Code is also important because moderation systems depend on technical design and engineering decisions. Professional codes alone may not be fully sufficient for cases like COVID misinformation moderation because these systems also involve politics, public health, freedom of speech, and cultural differences.

Question	ACM	IEEE
Main ethical emphasis	Transparency and accountability	Safety and technical responsibility
Most relevant principle	Avoid harm	Public welfare and safety
Primary responsibility	Ethical computing conduct	Engineering reliability
Main harm identified	Information misuse and censorship	Unsafe technical outcomes